Samantha Cervantes

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EDUCATION

Ph.D., Public Administration 2022 – 2027 (expected)
Maxwell School, Syracuse University
Fields: Urban Economics and Education Policy
Advisors: Amy Ellen Schwartz and Michah W. Rothbart

M.S., Applied Economics with Honors 2022
Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico

Certificate in Applied Statistics 2019
Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico

B.A., Business Administration, minor in Political Science 2018
Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Urban Policy, Education Policy, Neighborhood Effects, Economics of Crime

RESEARCH

Job Market Paper

The Intended and Unintended Impacts of a Crime-Deterrence Experiment on Academic Outcomes: Evidence from High-Intensity Streetlights
with Amy Ellen Schwartz

Cities routinely deploy place-based crime-deterrence interventions and evaluate them primarily by their effects on crime. Yet interventions that alter the physical environment around residents' homes can impose costs and confer benefits beyond crime reduction, and these may fall unevenly depending on where residents live relative to the intervention. We study a randomized experiment that installed 600,000-lumen light towers in public housing developments, which reduced crime (Chalfin et al., 2022; Mitre-Becerril et al., 2022) but may have imposed costs on nearby students through residential light intrusion. We link the experiment to administrative records of public school students, incident-level crime and arrest data, and detailed building and development characteristics, and use building height to proxy for likely light exposure, since students in shorter buildings lived, on average, vertically closer to the street-level towers. We find that average effects on crime exposure and academic outcomes are close to zero, while at higher doses, crime falls substantially, yet average academic effects remain near zero. These null averages conceal sharply opposing effects by building height, with students in taller buildings gaining 0.11 SD in math while students in shorter buildings lose 0.22 SD, a gap of 0.33 SD, with reading and attendance outcomes following the same pattern. Differences in crime exposure, school quality, and school changes do not explain the losses in shorter buildings nor their gap with taller buildings, and the height contrast disappears just outside the developments, where students face little direct light exposure. Three patterns point to sleep disruption as the mechanism: the losses emerge earlier for girls, are accompanied by large increases in overweight risk among girls, and are larger on noisier streets. Building height thus appears to shape whether students gain from reduced crime exposure or bear the costs of residential light intrusion.

WORKING PAPERS

"Hold Harmless for Whom? The Impact of COVID Era Policies for School Funding, Teachers, and Students" **(R&R at *Education Finance and Policy*)** with Michah W. Rothbart and Amy Ellen Schwartz

"How a Good School in the Neighborhood Affects Academic Outcomes" **(under review)**, with Sarah Cordes, Jeehee Han, and Amy Ellen Schwartz

WORKS IN PROGRESS

"The Impact of a Crime Deterrence Intervention on Political Behavior", with Ying Shi

"Housing Market Responses to Salient Police Interventions: Experimental Evidence from High-Intensity Streetlights", with Alexander Cardazzi

"The Long-Term Impacts of Neighborhood Violence on Youth Outcomes"

PRE-DOCTORAL RESEARCH

"The Effect of Public Transit Expansions on Crime: Evidence from Mexico City"

RESEARCH AND PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Associate, Center for Policy Research 2022 –
Professors Michah W. Rothbart and Amy Ellen Schwartz, Syracuse University

Research Assistant, Center for Competitiveness Studies 2019 – 2022
Professor Guillermo Abdel Musik, ITAM

Investment Consultant, Profuturo Pensiones 2018 – 2019
Mexico City, Mexico

TEACHING

Syracuse University, MPA Program

Fall 2026 Economics for Public Decisions

Spr 2025 Education Policy, Quantitative Analysis (Guest Lecturer)

Spr 2024, 2025 Quantitative Analysis

2023, 2024 Public Budgeting (Intensive Summer Courses)

Fall 2022 Public Budgeting

PRESENTATIONS

2026 APPAM (discussant); NYU Furman Center Speaker Series; Urban Economics Association (UEA); American Real Estate and Urban Economics Association (AREUEA); FLX Economics of Education Workshop; Capital District Applied Microeconomics Workshop; Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP)

2025 Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)

2024 Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM); Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP); Public Finance and Budgeting Northeastern Workshop

2023 Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)

GRANTS & AWARDS

First Place, Graduate Student Poster-Session 2026
Center for Policy Research, Syracuse University

Summer Dissertation Fellowship
Syracuse University

Ph.D. Department Research Grant 2025
Syracuse University

Financial Inclusion Essay Award 2021
National Banking and Securities Commission, Mexico City, Mexico

SERVICE

Graduate Student Representative, Center for Policy Research 2026 – 2027
Maxwell School, Syracuse University
Referee: *Educational Researcher, Journal of Behavioral Public Administration*

SKILLS

Software: Stata, R, QGIS, Python

Languages: English (fluent), Spanish (native)

REFERENCES

Amy Ellen Schwartz, Professor
University of Delaware
aeschwar@udel.edu

Michah W. Rothbart, Associate Professor
Syracuse University
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Ying Shi, Associate Professor
Syracuse University
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Robert Bifulco, Professor
Syracuse University
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